

PROGRESSION · TIMELINE · STRUCTURE

# authority-chain

Provenance chain — statute to regulation to guidance to case, walked in order.

# The chain descends from statute to practice.

## STATUTE

15 U.S.C. §6501

Congress, 1998 — verifiable parental consent for under-13 data.

## REGULATION

16 C.F.R. Part 312

FTC implementing rule; 2013 rewrite expanded covered identifiers.

## GUIDANCE

FTC Six-Step Compliance Plan

Staff guidance — non-binding, but cited in every consent order.

## CASE

In re Epic Games · 2022

\$245M consent order — operationalized "actual knowledge" standard.

# branching forks the chain where authority splits.

## STATUTE

15 U.S.C. §6501 COPPA, 1998

16 C.F.R. Part 312 FTC implementing rule

FTC Six-Step Compliance Plan staff guidance

In re Epic Games · 2022 \$245M consent order

In re YouTube/Google · 2019 \$170M consent order

# trail walks the chain as a breadcrumb.

|                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                      |                                                                                             |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>01</div> <div>STATUTE</div> <div>→</div> <div>15 U.S.C. §6501</div> <div>Verifiable parental consent for under-13 data.</div> | <div>02</div> <div>REGULATION</div> <div>→</div> <div>16 C.F.R. Part 312</div> <div>FTC implementing rule.</div> | <div>03</div> <div>GUIDANCE</div> <div>→</div> <div>FTC Six-Step Plan</div> <div>Cited in every consent order.</div> | <div>04</div> <div>CASE</div> <div>Epic Games · 2022</div> <div>\$245M consent order.</div> |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

# pyramid weights the tiers by force.

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15 U.S.C. §6501  
Congress, 1998 — consent for under-13 data.

REGULATION

16 C.F.R. Part 312  
FTC implementing rule.

GUIDANCE

FTC Six-Step Plan  
Staff guidance, non-binding.

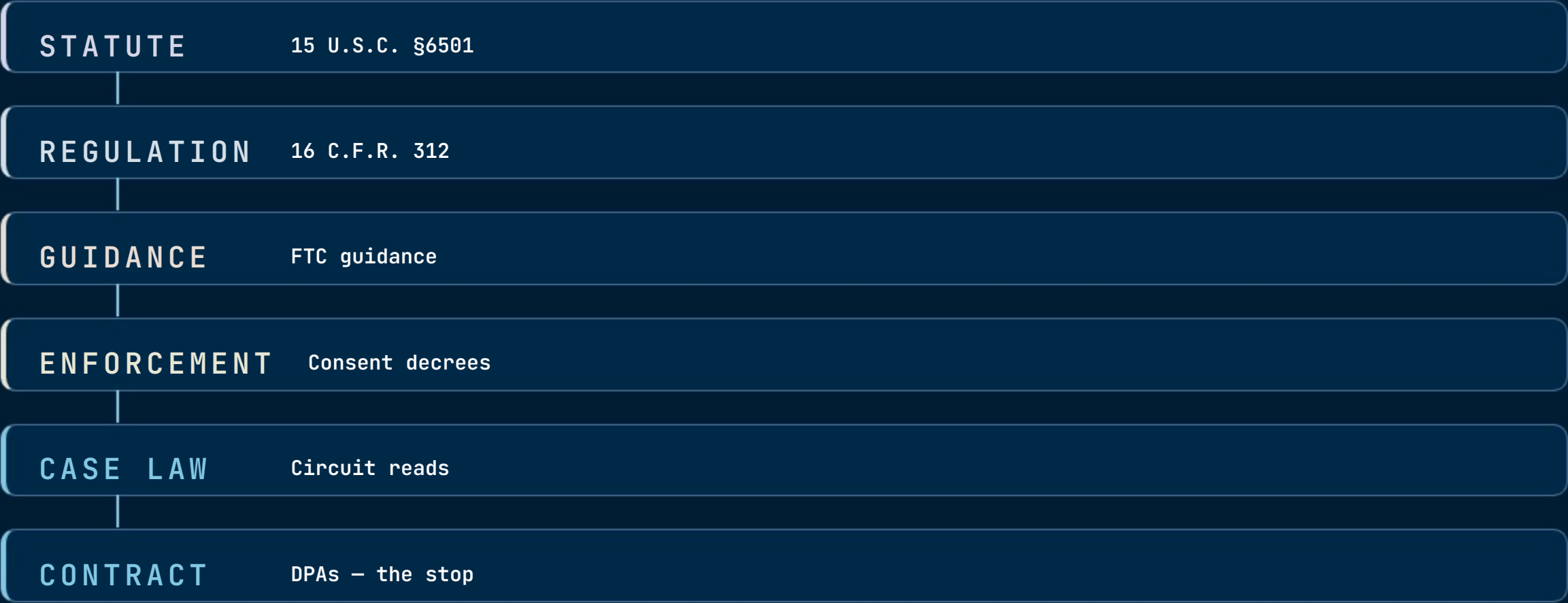
CASE

In re Epic Games · 2022  
\$245M consent order.

# bracket groups the tiers by actor.

|            |                                                                                                               |
|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| TREATY     | Charter of Fundamental Rights, Art. 8<br>EU primary law — protection of personal data is a fundamental right. |
| REGULATION | GDPR (EU) 2016/679<br>Directly applicable across all member states; sets the Art. 83 fine tiers.              |
| GUIDANCE   | EDPB Guidelines 04/2022<br>Harmonized methodology for calculating administrative fines.                       |
| DECISION   | DPC v. Meta · 2023<br>€1.2B fine — the largest GDPR penalty to date.                                          |

# Six tiers is the chain's ceiling.



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# When NOT to reach for authority-chain.

## Flat list of citations

If the rows have no tier hierarchy, use `list takeaway numbered` or `regulatory-update`. authority-chain earns its chrome only when the descent from statute to case is the point.

## Missing citation chip

The inline-code citation is the row's anchor; without it the gloss reads as opinion. Always cite, even for guidance and case rows.

## Out-of-order tiers

The chain reads as a descent: statute first, case last. Reversing it or skipping a tier breaks the metaphor the audience is using to follow you.

RELATED COMPONENTS

# See also.

`regulatory-update` — period-bounded changelog rather than a single rule's lineage

`list` — `takeaway numbered`: flat enumeration of requirements without tier hierarchy

`list-steps` — the rows are procedural steps rather than authority tiers